

Voices

The voice is a universal instrument. From the earliest times, humans have used their voices to call, warn, express emotion, and entertain. Singing is part of music-making in all cultures, both as a solo and group activity.

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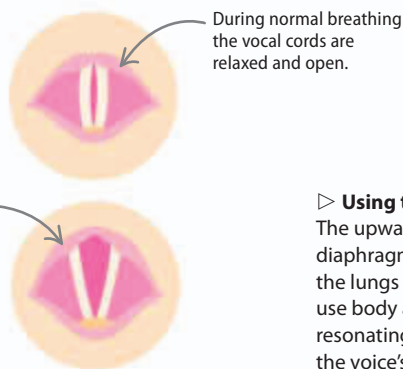
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How we sing

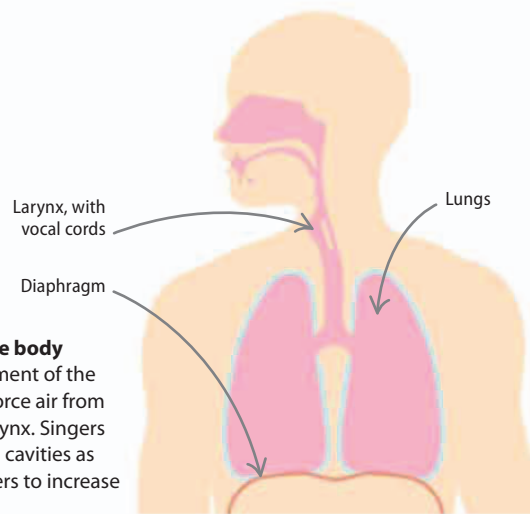
Correct breathing is the key to good singing. Singers breathe in through the nose and out through the mouth and nose. The lungs, diaphragm, and head provide support, power, tonal quality, and resonance to the sound produced by the vocal folds, or “cords.” To change the pitch or volume of a note, a singer uses ligaments in the larynx to control the vibration of the vocal cords.

When speaking or singing, the cords move back and forth, producing the sounds that become words.

▷ **How vocal cords work**
The vocal cords are elastic (stretchy). Air passing through causes them to vibrate, making a sound.

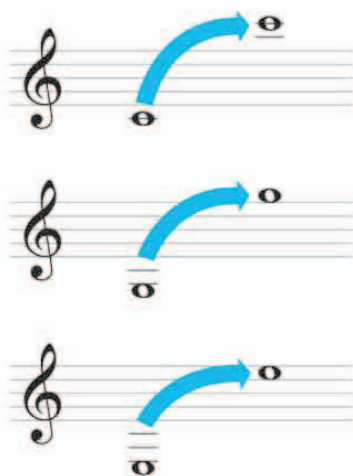


▷ **Using the whole body**
The upward movement of the diaphragm helps force air from the lungs to the larynx. Singers use body and head cavities as resonating chambers to increase the voice's power.



Different voices

When placed together, male and female voices can cover a range of around five octaves. Like a fingerprint, every voice has its own sound—with a distinctive color, or “timbre.” Soloists need individual power, while group singing usually requires voices to blend.



◁ Soprano and treble

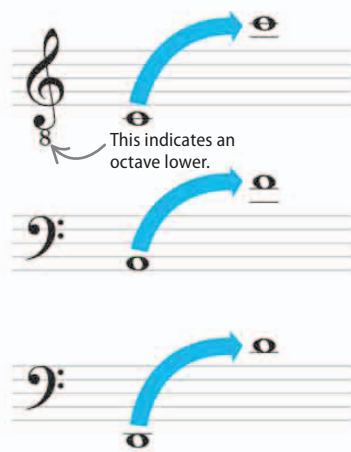
Soprano is the highest female voice. Boys with unbroken voices are normally described as trebles.

◁ Mezzo-soprano

With a lower range, the mezzo-soprano can make a richer sound in lower notes than a soprano.

◁ Alto, contralto, and counter-tenor

Contralto, or alto, is the lowest female voice. The highest male voice is the counter-tenor.



◁ Tenor

The tenor is a favorite soloist in a wide range of musical genres.

◁ Baritone

Between tenor and bass, the baritone sings in the middle range of the male voice.

◁ Bass

The lowest of all voices, the bass provides the bottom notes of harmonies and is crucial in ensemble singing.